

Regular Meeting
December 4, 2017
School Committee Meeting
Community Media Studio
Medford High School

The regular meeting of the Medford School Committee was called to order by Mayor Burke in the Community Media Center at Medford High School at 7:04 p.m. Those present were Ms. Kreatz, Mr. Skerry, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke and Superintendent Belson. Ms. Cugno, Ms. DiBenedetto and Ms. Mustone were absent.

Medford High School student representative Sebastian Tringale was also in attendance.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot that the minutes of November 20, 2017 be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 4
No: 0
Absent: 3

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Kreatz that the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved:

Voted: That the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 4 Kreatz, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 3 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Mustone

Ms. Cugno arrived at 7:06 p.m.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot that the Payrolls be approved:

Voted: That the Payrolls be approved

Roll Call:

Yea: 5 Cugno, Kreatz, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 2 DiBenedetto, Mustone

Committee of the Whole Meeting Minutes – November 13, 2017

Ms. Van der Kloot read the minutes. Ms. Van der Kloot reported that the meeting was called to order at 7:00 p.m. by Mayor Burke in Superintendent's Conference Room at Medford High School. The following members were present at the meeting: Mayor Burke, Vice-Chair Ann Marie Cugno, Erin DiBenedetto, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Robert Skerry and Paulette Vander Kloot (7-0-0) also Michael Ruggiero and Paul Ruseau School Committee members elect. Also present were the following: Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson, Assistant Superintendent Diane Caldwell, Director of

Pupil Services Kathleen Medaglio, Director of Curriculum Bernadette Ricciardelli, Director of Finance and Administration Kirsteen Patterson, Director of Foreign Language Rita DiCarlo, Supervisor of Health Services Toni Vento, Assistant Athletic Director Rachel Perry, Headmaster John Perella, Principal Paul D'Alleva, Principal Jacob Edwards, Assistant Principal Nick Tucci, Athletic Trainer Tanya Cashman-Timsit, Registrar Curtis Tuden and community members Tammy Simonides, Marie Petrides, Angela Moore David Liu, Melanie McLaughlin, Tanya Sullivan and Jameel Webb-Davis. Transcript reporter Miranda Willson was also in attendance.

All rose to salute the Flag.

Mayor Burke stated that the purpose of the meeting was to discuss the following issues as requested by the School Committee:

- School Brains
- Field Trip Policy
- Follow-up on Student Concussions
- Report on North Medford Bus

Mayor Burke then called upon the Superintendent for an overview.

Superintendent Belson made the following remarks:

The evening's meeting will address four issues that required reports based upon School Committee motions. Materials have been provided on each of the four items. Staff is present to amplify on each and answer questions. There are individuals in the audience tonight that would like to speak on three of the four issues. Significant staff work has been done in preparation of these reports for your consideration.

On another matter Foreign Language Director Rita DiCarlo has an announcement and will be seeking permission for a New York City field trip this December. A formal vote will be asked for at our next meeting but we are looking for informal consent so that plans and arrangements can go forward.

At this time the committee agreed to take the items listed in a different order.

The first item was the Report on the North Medford bus capacity and ridership at Medford High School. Director of Administration and Finance Kirsteen Patterson gave this report. Assistant Principal Nicholas Tucci verified the report.

There are two buses coming from North Medford in the morning. In the afternoon there are between 45-50 riders daily which is within capacity. At this time there is no need to add another bus. Administration will keep the Committee informed as demand increases. The next item was on student concussions. Information was provided by Health Services Supervisor Toni Vento and Athletic Trainer Tanya Cashman-Timsit. The listing also provided information on non-athletic concussions.

As part of the discussions on concussions parent Tammy Simonides spoke on her son's experience at Beverly High School. She asserted that her son was injured during a JV soccer game and that there was inadequate trainer/medical coverage by the Beverly staff. She believes that Beverly Public Schools did not have a certified trainer at the game. Her son suffered a head injury, chipped teeth and nose bleeds. Her concern focused upon safety at away games.

The Superintendent spoke with the Beverly Superintendent. Athletic Director Maloney spoke with the Beverly A.D. Assistant Athletic Director Rachel Perry also investigated and spoke with the parent. Beverly Public Schools asserts that their trainer is certified

but did not treat the player. Ms. Simonides was pleased with how Medford handles injuries but was very upset at the Beverly response.

Concern was also expressed on how the game official allowed play to continue after the injury took place. The Superintendent will be conferring with the MIAA regarding this matter. The School Committee will be updated as any new information emerges.

The next item discussed was the Field Trip Policy (see attached). Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson reviewed the document. Administrators Paul D'Alleva, Toni Vento, and Kathy Medaglio contributed comments during the discussions. SEPAC chairperson Melanie McLaughlin raised equity issues about the policy and commented that SEPAC should have been consulted as the policy was formulated.

The Andrews annual New York field trip became the topic of discussion. Two buses were allocated accommodating 90 students plus chaperones. There was a deadline for application and down payment. The cost of the trip was \$550.

Among the 90 students on the trip 52 were 19 students who either had an IEP or a 504 plan. This is 19% of the participants. An extra bus plus other expenses would add approximately \$7500 to the trip and would not be absorbed by existing revenue. The trip with 2 buses and 90 students costs \$52,655. The 8 students on the wait list would not generate sufficient revenue to offset the additional cost. There were 4 scholarships already factored into the trip and approximately \$3000 was raised through a fund raiser. Ms. McLaughlin asserted that the trip excluded students with disabilities. That every such trip should be planned to serve all interested students.

The issue raised several points:

- Can field trips be planned with application deadlines if those deadlines are applicable to all students?
- Should field trips be limited if the economics cannot be balanced?
- Should the cost of medical services be shared by all participants or subsidized by the school system?

After continued discussion the policy was tabled. Administrators will bring forward a revised policy that addresses the issues.

The final issue of the evening was on School Brains. Headmaster Perella and Data Information Specialist/Registrar Curtis Tuden were present with a report (see attached). The Headmaster reported that changes had been made to address the GPA concerns raised during the spring by Mr. David Liu. Mr. Tuden provided a chart that showed the increase in usage by parents and teachers. More will be done going forward. This is a work in progress but it is moving forward. Mr. Liu was still skeptical about the accuracy of the reporting system. He revisited his concerns from last spring. Administrators asserted that the changes would work. The School Committee asked to be informed as the year progressed. The meeting was adjourned at 10:05 p.m.

Ms. Mustone arrived at 7:10 p.m.

Discussion:

Ms. Kreatz said that she has been in touch with Ms. Simonides and asked if anything has been filed with the MIAA yet. Superintendent Belson replied that Beverly strongly disputes Mrs. Simonides' case and there is a distinct difference of opinion between the parties. Ms. Van der Kloot commented that if one of our students was playing while hurt

why wasn't he treated by a trainer? Superintendent Belson answered that the referee did not blow the whistle to stop play. We need to get more information. Mr. Skerry asked if the game official has been notified to find out who the referees were. The Superintendent said not yet. Ms. Cugno asked if anyone was filming the game and asked that the Superintendent check. He replied that it was a junior varsity game but will check. Student Tringale commented on the importance of the concussions especially if another concussion occurs. Ms. Cugno said that the MIAA came out with a concussion policy so our coaches are now trained. Superintendent Belson read an email from the Beverly Superintendent and said that this is an ongoing investigation. Mayor Burke asked to be sent a follow up report when complete.

On the motion of Ms. Kreatz seconded by Mr. Skerry to approve the minutes of the Committee of the Whole meeting of November 13, 2017 as amended:

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

Ms. DiBenedetto arrived at 7:22 p.m.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto to table the minutes of November 15, 2017

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Committee of the Whole Minutes – November 27, 2017

Mayor Burke gave an overview of the highlights. Mayor Burke stated the purpose of the meeting: "to meet with the Executive Director of the MASC to discuss the Superintendent search criteria and options."

Mayor Burke called upon Superintendent Belson for an overview:

The Superintendent distributed materials to members including:

- Job description current for Medford Superintendent
- MASC School Committee Roles and Governance
- Current Superintendent's Contract
- Medford Public Schools Current Highlights

The Superintendent then introduced Glenn Koocher, Executive Director of the MASC. Director Koocher distributed the MASC manual for decision-making regarding the recruitment and hiring of a school superintendent.

There was substantial discussion on the composition of the search committee. Mayor was designated to select members (7-0). There should be at least three teachers, an administrator and a student in addition to School Committee members and community members. The Diversity Director will also be on the committee (7-0).

The School Committee voted to review internal candidates first. (7-0)

The School Committee will meet again on December 11, 2017 to continue its work.

On the motion of Ms. Cugno seconded by Mr. Skerry to approve the minute of the Committee of the Whole meeting of November 27, 2017:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Community Partnership

Retta Smith – School Breakfast

Ms. Smith presented information regarding school by school participation rates of school breakfast in Medford.

Discussion:

Mayor Burke asked that principals re-evaluate having breakfast in the classrooms. Ms. DiBenedetto asked what percent of forms are received back for free/reduced lunch. She commented that parents should be informed that it entitles them to more than breakfast and lunch. It helps them with SAT's and college application fees as well. She would like returns broken down by school. Ms. Patterson said that they have engaged to have the application in different languages. We are capturing more money through the portal and through the parent center. Superintendent Belson commented that this is the breakfast program. We will give you a report with total numbers.

On the motion to receive a report on return of free/reduced lunch and to reach out to principals regarding after bell breakfast:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot seconded by Ms. Cugno to take papers out of order:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on Student Survey on Substance Abuse

Superintendent Belson reported that every two years we conduct surveys on student behaviors that encompass risk and protective factors. The attached survey results are from the Communities that Care instrument. The report was prepared by the Medford Board of Health, Office of Prevention and Outreach. The staff of the Medford Public Schools works closely with this office to monitor student behaviors and assess the effectiveness of school and community programs and interventions. Representatives of the Board of Health/Office of Prevention and Outreach as well as Medford Public

Schools staff are present to discuss results and answer any questions you may have on this topic. Superintendent Belson introduced Penny Funairole to present the results of the survey. Ms. Funairole said that the survey asked youth to respond to questions on risky behaviors (substance use, delinquency, dropping out, and violence). The survey also asked questions to understand risk and protective factors that either increase risk or reduce protective factors leading to risky behaviors. Addressing risk factors and building on protective factors has been shown to be effective in increasing healthy decision making, including choosing not to use tobacco, alcohol or other drugs. She continued with a presentation of the results of the survey. Vaping is a big concern this year and was discussed in great length.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno asked if the survey asks when they do it and why? Ms. Funairole answered no but there is a question that asks where they get it. Ms. Cugno commented that she thinks it is important to know that. She would like to see it expanded more. Ms. Funairole answered that it is a national survey so the questions are vetted nationally. Ms. Cugno asked what the discipline is for vaping? Ms. Vento answered the same as for tobacco. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if we have a vaping policy. Superintendent Belson answered that we use the tobacco policy since vaping is relatively new. Ms. DiBenedetto would like this school committee to work on this and add a vaping policy to the student handbook.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto seconded by Mr. Skerry to develop a vaping policy and have in place in the student handbook for the next school year.

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Ms. Van der Kloot commented about two Medford High students who spoke at a forum about addiction. They are good kids. She said she is worried about the transition to college and the loneliness it can bring. Ms. Perry said that Armstrong Ambulance did a presentation to seniors regarding transition. Ms. Van der Kloot suggested having the students come to speak to our students. Student Tringale said that the reasons that kids are vaping so much is that they don't think it is harmful. It is important to get the facts out. Community member Hanna O'Brien commented that Chris Hernon spoke to all student athletes and was very impressive. He is a motivational speaker and will help everyone. Ms. Van der Kloot suggested having posters made that shows that Juile equals the nicotine of a pack of cigarettes. Mr. Skerry said that there was a great article recently in the Boston Globe on juiling.

On the motion to have the graphics department make posters and to engage a motivational speaker:

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Member elect Ruggiero asked if we have a sense of the number on underage heroin overdoses in Medford. Ms. Perry answered none.

On the motion the report was accepted and placed on file

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion to revert back to regular order of business:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve MHS/MVTHS Graduation Date and Location

Superintendent Belson read the correspondence from Headmaster Perella requesting that graduation be held on Wednesday June 6th 2018 at 6:00 p.m. at the Gantcher Family and Convocation Center at Tufts University. Superintendent Belson informed the community that there would be a guest speaker this year, William Cummings of the Cummings Foundation.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto seconded by Ms. Kreatz the graduation date of June 6th 2018 at Tufts University be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Financial Report

Director of Finance and Administration Kirsteen Patterson presented the report. Ms. Patterson reported that 42.91% of the total budget has been expended and/or encumbered to date. Transition continues in the business office but it is fully staffed to date. Salary increments are scheduled for many of the bargaining units in January. A large investment has been made to replace and repair security cameras throughout the district at all buildings. Significant funding was provided for each school to increase available laptops and portable carts. The most recent E-Rate approval will further improve connectivity district wide and matching dollars are requested from the city for the 60% reimbursement to be implemented at the end of 2018. This is year three of a three year contract with Eastern Bus Company. Routes are continuously reviewed for overcrowding and time efficiencies with adjustments made where feasible for safety purposes. Electricity continues to be volatile in the marketplace and a slightly higher rate will begin in November 2018. Natural gas rates have been very favorable and utilization has been lower due to milder winters but the cold has not arrived for this year. In summary expenditures are in line with budget projections and will be continually monitored and reviewed.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot asked for an explanation of the new payroll codes. Ms. Patterson explained that our codes did not align with accounting codes. Strictly an accounting

procedure. Ms. Kreatz questioned the security cameras. She said there are still many parental concerns. Ms. Patterson replied that they have addressed all cameras. This is not complete some still are being worked on. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if key cameras are functioning? Ms. Patterson said that they are still in the process but should be complete within a couple of weeks. Superintendent Belson added that cameras are fragile. We will need to budget money for this. We are covering important areas. Ms. DiBenedetto said that Attorney Bill O’Keefe is willing to provide cameras. Superintendent Belson commented that they are not all compatible; a few were.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to send a thank you letter to Bill O’Keefe for his previous contributions:

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

MS. DiBenedetto asked about the business office restructure. Ms. Patterson answered that a maternity leave was not covered and that they are also transitioning a team member. No one added just a replacement of staff. Ms. DiBenedetto requested a listing of staff names/job titles. Superintendent Belson said that they will be coming forward with Human Resource department discussion further down road. Ms. DiBenedetto requested that this be added to requested reports.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot the report was accepted and placed on file

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Report on Bilingual Education Legislation

Superintendent Belson reported that fifteen years ago an initiative petition was enacted by Massachusetts voters that required most language learners to be taught in “Sheltered English Immersion” (SEI) classrooms. Under this plan these students were instructed using books and lessons in English rather than in their native languages. Ron Unz from California launched this ballot question after two successful referendum campaigns in Arizona and California. The ballot question came shortly after 9/11 and had strong support from Gubernatorial Candidate Mitt Romney and former B.U. President and Chairperson of DOE John Silber. There was strong sentiment that English needed to be the only main language and that immersion as a methodology would produce superior results to the Transitional Bilingual Education approach (TBE). Research demonstrates that the switch to SEI from TBE has mixed results. Recent results show that only 20% of SEI students could achieve proficiency after five years. While a student might be able to converse socially in one to two years, the acquisition of cognitive language would typically take about seven years.

Another factor has been that teachers were not adequately trained to implement an SEI program. It was not an easy transition. Recently the state has mandated that teachers who work with EL students must acquire an SEI endorsement. While an improvement, it is still a stretch to assume that SEI endorsed teachers could teach significant content

lessons to multiple levels of language learners and across a multitude of different languages. There are approximately 90,000 students in Massachusetts who are not fluent in English. The new legislation will allow school systems to blend/tailor TBE/ELL programs that are more flexible and responsive to the unique needs of learners. It is a rejection of the one size fits all formula that was enacted in 2002. DESE has not yet developed the guidance and regulation that will govern the implementation of this new law. We probably will not see a DESE manual until this summer. Therefore, we cannot move forward until we know the rules of the road. Changes in our programming will be targeted initially to the upper grades where deeper content acquisition is required. We will need to learn about new teacher licensure requirements that will identify both content and pedagogical expertise. There will be a need for new books and materials. The rollout of this type of programming will take three to five years. We will be working with the state and colleagues to develop best practices and strategies for successful implementation. It is doubtful that any new source of funding will become available either from State or Federal funds. In Medford we will be working to determine the best way to distribute EL students at both the elementary and middle school levels. There will be tradeoffs with every move we make. As we prepare for SY 2018-2019 we will need to meet to discuss the options for student enrollment and distribution. The administration is working to prepare plans that the School Committee can consider and choose. The longer term implementation of TBE/SEI options will come later as we become cognizant of the DESE rules. He introduced Paul Texeira to answer any questions.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno asked when a student comes to the high school are they partnered with another student especially at lunch or other activities to help them. Mr. Texeira answered that they are setup with an EL teacher in a new comer classroom. Ms. Van der Kloot asked about the pilot program in Portuguese next year. Mr. Texiera said that we won't move forward until we have state guidance. Ms. Van der Kloot asked about the changes this year with the Roberts and Brooks? Mr. Texeira asked what exactly? Ms. Van der Kloot said the families and siblings. She requested a report moving forward. Superintendent Belson said it is a complex issue and will be part of an upcoming report. Ms. Mustone questioned the length of training. Mr. Texeira answered 40 hours and it is very specific.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto the report was accepted and placed on file

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve Revised Field Trip Policy

Director of Curriculum Bernadette Ricciardelli stated that on Monday, November 13th we presented a draft of the districts Field Trip Policy at the Committee of the Whole meeting. We have taken comments and suggestions into consideration and have made several adjustments. The document has been reviewed by Gail Treanor, Toni Vento, Beverly Nelson and Bernadette Ricciardelli. She said there are five revisions and went

through the changes. Our recommendation therefore is for the School Committee to approve the revised version.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot commented on page 4 (b) out of country travel receiving 6 months prior approval; she would like it to say prior to payment. Ms. DiBenedetto thanked them for meeting the needs of all students with the statement. She would like to see the forms before approving. Dr. Ricciardello said that the forms are still being developed. Ms. DiBenedetto suggested that they table until forms are finished and amendment complete. Mr. Skerry suggested approved the field trip policy with amendments and asked if they could be done for December 18th. Ms. Nelson answered that there are many forms and they are trying to make them as concise and user friendly as possible. She said that the forms should not hold up the policy.

On the motion to accept the field trip policy with 1 amendment page 4 (b)

“All school-sponsored trips which involve domestic overnight travel must receive prior approval of the Superintendent and a vote by the Medford School Committee in a timely way

Roll Call:

Yea: 6 Cugno, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 1 DiBenedetto

Medford School Committee Resolution:

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family Sandy Toomey. Mrs. Toomey was a community activist and longtime Medford resident.

Medford School Committee Resolution:

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family Margaret Regan. Mrs. Regan was a teacher at the Swan School for many years.

A moment of silence was held.

On the motion of Cugno seconded by Ms. Mustone the meeting was adjourned at 9:33 p.m.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

Respectfully submitted:

Paulette Van der Kloot
Secretary

